Module

2

Adapting Your Message to Your Audience

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

Module 2 can help you best meet the needs of your audiences for communication. After completing the module, you should be able to

- **LO 2-1** **Understand expectations from your organization.**
- **LO 2-2** **Define audiences for messages.**
- **LO 2-3** **Apply strategies for audience analysis with PAIBOC.**
- **LO 2-4** **Apply strategies for individual and group audience analyses.**
- **LO 2-5** **Apply strategies for audience needs analysis.**
- **LO 2-6** **Adapt messages for audiences.**
- **LO 2-7** **Choose channels for audiences.**

Understanding your audience is fundamental to the success of any message. You need to adapt your message to fit the audience's goals, interests, and needs.

Analyzing your audience and adapting your message can be done in a cynical, manipulative way. It can also be done in a sensitive, empathic, ethical way. Audiences have a keen sense for messages that try to manipulate them; empathic analysis and adaptation are almost always more successful, as well as being more ethical.

Some students pride themselves on their "honesty" in not adapting their discourse to anyone and in criticizing their bosses as sharply as they might younger brothers and sisters. But almost all organizations expect deference to people in authority. And customers have enough options to deal only with companies that treat them respectfully.

With the rapid pace of communication today, analyzing audiences is a must. Before sending that next tweet or e-mail message, for instance, think carefully about all of the audiences that may read it. Do your best, but should mistakes happen, learn from them. Careful audience analysis combined with experience will help you to avoid problems.



Building a Critical Skill

Understanding What Your Organization Wants LO 2-1

Michelle wondered whether her boss was sexist. Everyone else who had joined the organization when she did had been promoted. Her boss never seemed to have anything good to say about her or her work.

Michelle didn't realize that, in her boss's eyes, she wasn't doing good work. Michelle was proud of her reports; she thought she was the best writer in the office. But her boss valued punctuality, and Michelle's reports were always late.

Just as every sport has rules about scoring, so, too, do workplaces have rules about what "counts." Even in the same industry, different organizations and different supervisors may care about different things. One boss circles misspelled words and posts the offending message on a bulletin board for everyone to see. Other people are more tolerant of errors. One company values original ideas, while another workplace tells employees just to do what they're told. One supervisor likes technology and always buys the latest hardware and software; another is technophobic and has to be persuaded to get needed upgrades.

Succeeding in an organization depends first on understanding what "counts" at your organization. To find out what counts in your organization:

- Ask your boss, "What parts of my job are most important? What's the biggest thing I could do to improve my work?"
- Listen to the stories colleagues tell about people who have succeeded and those who have failed. When you see patterns, check for confirmation: "So his real problem was that he didn't socialize with co-workers?" This gives your colleagues a chance to provide feedback: "Well, it was more than never joining us for lunch. He didn't really seem to care about the company."
- Observe. See who is praised, who is promoted.

Understanding, by the way, can and should be a two-way street. Online shoe retailer Zappos.com listened to employees who said they wanted a workplace that is more accommodating to their lifestyle. The result was a nap room for a quick snooze and social events that include after-hours mixers and



lighthearted "parades" in the office. With $1 billion in sales in 2009 alone, the company also encourages its 1,500 employees to tweet about Zappos and hosts free daily tours of its Las Vegas headquarters. The work still gets done. In 2012, Zappos was named one of *CNNMoney's* 100 Best Companies to Work For.

Source: Morley Safer, "The 'Millennials' Are Coming," *60 Minutes,* November 11, 2007; and Jake Chessum, "How to Make Customers Love You," *Inc.,* 2010. Downloaded on February 12, 2010, at http://www.inc.com/ss/how-to-make-customers-love-you; and "100 Best Companies to Work For," *CNNMoney,* February 6, 2012, http://money.cnn.com/magazines/fortune/bestcompanies/2012/snapshots/11.html.

Who is my audience? LO 2-2

► *More people than you might think!*

In an organizational setting, a message may have five separate audiences.[1]

1. The **primary audience** will decide whether to accept your recommendations or will act on the basis of your message. You must reach the decision maker to fulfill your purposes.
2. The **secondary audience** may be asked to comment on your message or to implement your ideas after they've been approved. Secondary audiences can also include lawyers

who may use your message—perhaps years later—as evidence of your organization's culture and practices.

3. The **initial audience** receives the message first and routes it to other audiences. Sometimes the initial audience also tells you to write the message.
4. A **gatekeeper** has the power to stop your message before it gets to the primary audience. A secretary who decides who gets to speak to or see the boss is a gatekeeper. Sometimes the supervisor who assigns the message is also the gatekeeper; however, sometimes the gatekeeper is higher in the organization. In some cases, gatekeepers exist outside the organization.
5. A **watchdog audience,** though it does not have the power to stop the message and will not act directly on it, has political, social, or economic power. The watchdog pays close attention to the transaction between you and the primary audience and may base future actions on its evaluation of your message.

As the charts in Figures 2.1 and 2.2 show, one person or group can be part of two audiences. Frequently, a supervisor is both the initial audience and the gatekeeper. Sometimes the initial audience is also the primary audience that will act on the message.

Figure 2.1 The Audiences for a Marketing Plan

Writer	An account executive in an ad agency
Initial audience	Her boss, who asks her to write the plan
Gatekeeper	Her boss, who must approve the plan before it goes to the client
Primary audience	The executive committee of the client company, which will decide whether to adopt the plan
Secondary audiences	The marketing staff of the client company, who will be asked for comments on the plan The artists, writers, and media buyers who will implement the plan if it is accepted

Figure 2.2 The Audiences for a Consulting Report

Writers	Two workers at a consulting think tank
Initial audience	A consortium of manufacturers, which hires the think tank to investigate how proposed federal regulations would affect manufacturing, safety, and cost
Gatekeeper	The consortium. If the consortium doesn't like the report, it won't send it on to the federal government.
Primary audience	The federal government agency that regulates this consumer product. It will set new regulations based in part (the manufacturers hope) on this report. Within this audience are economists, engineers, and policymakers.
Secondary audiences	The general public Other manufacturers of the product Other clients and potential clients of the consulting think tank The consulting think tank's competitors
Watchdog audience	Industry reviewers who read drafts of the report and commented on it. Although they had no direct power over this report, their goodwill was important for the consulting company's image—and its future contracts. Their comments were the ones that authors took more seriously as they revised their drafts.



In what can at best be described as a baffling move, Nivea for Men ran an advertisement in *Esquire* suggesting men "re-civilize" themselves, complete with an image of a man in business casual clothes tossing away a head with a beard and Afro. The company later apologized for the ad, which prompted public outcry. Even if some audiences are untroubled by the content of a message, good communicators take into consideration all of the audiences for that message. At the very least, they should re-think messages that appeal to some audiences at the expense of other audiences.

Source: Ellen Tumposky, "Nivea for Men Pulls Plug on Ad It Calls 'Offensive,'" *ABC News,* August 19, 2011, http://abcnews.go.com/Business/nivea-men-pulls-plug-ad-calls-offensive/story?id=14342539.

Why is my audience so important? LO 2-3

▶ *To be successful, messages must meet the audiences' needs.*

Good business communication is audience-centered. Audience is central to both PAIBOC and to the communication process.



On his blog, Robert Greene, who co-wrote the best-selling *The 50th Law* with musician 50 Cent, notes the performer's four principles for reaching his audience. Among them is to "crush as much distance as possible between you and your audience," reaching people and their inner lives and reflecting their spirit in your message.

Source: Robert Greene, "Four Things 50 Cent Can Teach You About Connecting with Your Audience," downloaded on February 16, 2010, at http://www.copyblogger.com/robert-greene-50-cent/.

Audience and PAIBOC

Think about the PAIBOC questions in Module 1 (▶▶ p. 12). Of the six questions, the five in blue relate to audience.

P What are your **purposes** in writing or speaking?

Your purposes come from you and your organization. Your audience determines how you achieve those purposes, but not what the purposes are.

A Who is (are) your **audience(s)?** How do members of your audience differ? What characteristics are relevant to this particular message?

These questions ask directly about your audience.

I What **information** must your message include?

The information you need to give depends on your audience. You need to say more when the topic is new to your audience. If your audience has heard something but may have forgotten it, you'll want to protect readers' egos by saying "As you know," or putting the information in a subordinate clause: "Because we had delivery problems last quarter, ..."

B What reasons or reader **benefits** can you use to support your position?

What counts as a good reason and what is a benefit depends on your audience. For some audiences, personal experience counts as a good reason. Other audiences are more persuaded by scientific studies or by experts. For some people, saving money is a good benefit of growing vegetables. Other people may care less about the money than about avoiding chemicals, growing varieties that aren't available in grocery stores, or working outside in the fresh air. ▶▶ Module 8 gives more information on developing reader benefits.



Instant Replay

Five Kinds of Audiences

Initial

Is first to receive the message; may assign message.

Gatekeeper

Has the power to stop the message before it gets to primary audience.

Primary

Decides whether to accept recommendations; acts.

Secondary

Comments on message or implements recommendations.

Watchdog

Has political, social, or economic power; may base future actions on its evaluation of your message.

Carl Caspers understands the market for Harmony Systems' prostheses because he is part of it. Often, however, you'll have to analyze audiences of which you are not a part.



O What **objection(s)** can you expect your reader(s) to have? What negative elements of your message must you deemphasize or overcome?

Different audiences will have different attitudes. One audience may object to a price increase. Another audience may expect price changes as routine and not be bothered by them. ▶▶ Module 12 on persuasion gives more information on overcoming objections.

C How will the **context** affect reader response? Think about your relationship to the reader, morale in the organization, the economy, the time of year, and any special circumstances.

People exist in a context. How well they know you, how they feel about you and your organization, how well the economy is doing, even what's been in the news recently will all influence the way they respond to your message.



Understanding potential objections from audiences requires thinking about the context of the situation, including timing. When the Cedar River flooded his home with 13 feet of water and destroyed most of his possessions, Justin Van Fleet asked for help from the Federal Emergency Management Agency (FEMA). He was living in a FEMA trailer when, after repeated applications, he was granted more than $20,000 from the agency. The following March, however, Van Fleet received a letter from FEMA stating he should never have received the money and had 30 days to repay it. The agency admitted to such mistakes but also noted by law it's required to recover funds—little comfort to thousands of Americans who collectively received more than $22 million because of FEMA errors.

Source: Ryan J. Foley, "FEMA Asks for Return of Disaster Aid," May 10, 2011, http://news.yahoo.com/s/ap/20110510/ap_on_re_us/us_fema_reclaiming_aid.

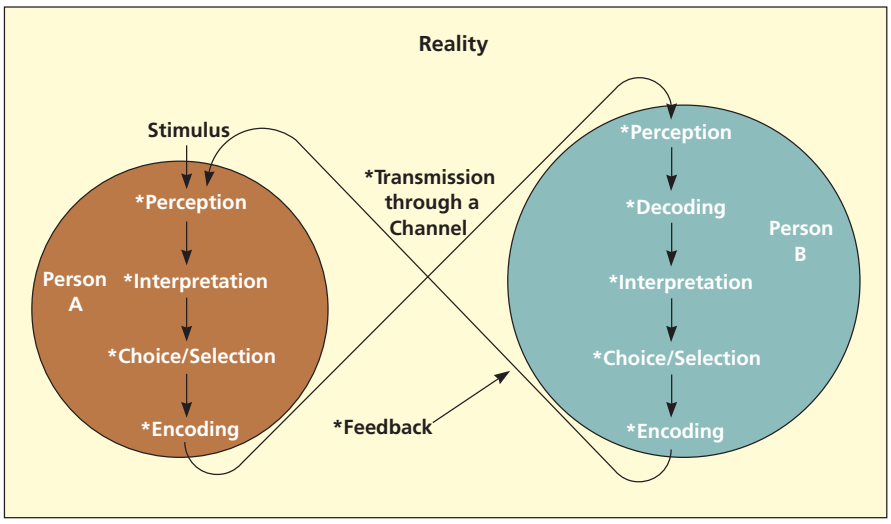
Audience and the Communication Process

Audience is also central to the communication process.

The following model of the communication process drastically simplifies what is perhaps the most complex of human activities. However, even a simplified model can give us a sense of the complexity of the communication process. And the model is useful in helping us see where and why miscommunication occurs. Figure 2.3 shows the basic process that occurs when one person tries to communicate ideas to someone else.

The process begins when Person A (let's call him Alex) **perceives** some stimulus. Here we are talking about literal perception: the ability to see, to hear, to taste, to smell, to touch. Next, Alex **interprets** what he has perceived. Is it important? Unusual? The next step is for Alex to **choose** or **select** the information he wishes to send to Person B (whom we'll call Barbara). Now Alex is ready to put his ideas into words. (Some people argue that we can think only in words and would put this stage before interpretation and choice.) Words are not the only way to convey ideas; gestures, clothing, and pictures can carry meaning nonverbally. The stage of putting ideas into any of these symbols is called **encoding.** Then Alex must **transmit** the message to Barbara using some **channel.** Channels include memos, phone calls, meetings, billboards, TV ads, and e-mail, to name just a few.

To receive the message, Barbara must first **perceive** it. Then she must **decode** it, that is, extract meaning from the symbols. Barbara then repeats the steps Alex has gone through:



***Noise (and miscommunication) can occur here.**

Figure 2.3 A Model of Two-Person Communication with Feedback



A test question featuring a talking pineapple ended up baffling eighth graders on a recent standardized exam. Though offered in the context of a fable, the concept of a piece of fruit challenging anyone to a race so confused students that the question ultimately was thrown out. Care must be taken to anticipate how audiences will understand or interpret communication, especially if it presents unusual ideas.

Source: Valerie Strauss, ""Talking Pineapple Question on Standardized Test Baffles Students," *The Washington Post,* April 20, 2012, http://www.washingtonpost.com/blogs/answer-sheet/post/talking-pineapple-question-on-standardized-test-baffles-students/2012/04/20/gIQA8i01VT_blog.html.

interpreting the information, choosing a response, and encoding it. The response Barbara sends to Alex is called **feedback.** Feedback may be direct and immediate or indirect and delayed; it may be verbal or nonverbal.

Noise can interfere with every aspect of the communication process. Noise may be physical or psychological. Physical noise could be a phone line with static, a lawn mower roaring outside a classroom, or handwriting that is hard to read. Psychological noise could include disliking a speaker, being concerned about something other than the message, or already having one's mind made up on an issue.

Channel overload occurs when the channel cannot handle all the messages that are being sent. A small business may have only two phone lines; no one else can get through if both lines are in use. **Information overload** occurs when more messages are transmitted than the human receiver can handle. Some receivers process information "first come, first served." Some may try to select the most important messages and ignore others. A third way is to depend on abstracts or summaries prepared by other people. None of these ways is completely satisfactory.

At every stage, both Alex and Barbara could misperceive, misinterpret, choose badly, encode poorly, or choose inappropriate channels. Miscommunication can also occur because different people have different frames of reference. We always interpret messages in light of our personal experiences, our cultures and subcultures, and even the point in history at which we live.

Successful communication depends on the common ground between you and your audience. Choose information that your audience needs and will find interesting. Encode your message in words and other symbols the audience will understand. Transmit the message along a channel that your audience will attend to.

What do I need to know about my audience(s)? LO 2-4

▶ *Everything that's relevant to what you're writing or talking about.*

Almost everything about your audience is relevant to some message. But for any particular message, only a few facts about your audience will be relevant.

Since the factors that matter vary depending on the situation, no one-size-fits-all list of questions for audience analysis exists. In general, you need to use common sense and empathy. **Empathy** is the ability to put yourself in someone else's shoes, to feel with that person. Empathy requires not being self-centered because, in all probability, the audience is *not* just like you. Use what you know about people and about organizations to predict likely responses.

Analyzing Individuals and Members of Groups

When you write or speak to people in your own organization and in other organizations you work closely with, you may be able to analyze your audience as individuals. You may already know your audience; it will usually be easy to get additional information by talking to members of your audience, talking to people who know your audience, and observing your audience.

In other organizational situations, you'll analyze your audience as members of a group: "taxpayers who must be notified that they owe more income tax," "customers living in the northeast side of the city," or "employees with small children."

Information that is most often helpful includes the following:

- How much the audience knows about your topic
- Demographic factors, such as age, income, number of children, and so forth
- Personality
- Values and beliefs
- Past behavior

Message/Purpose	Audience	Relevant Factors
Memo announcing that the company will reimburse employees for tuition if they take work-related college courses	All employees	• Attitudes toward education (some people find courses fun; others may be intimidated) • Time available (some may be too busy) • Interest in being promoted or in getting cross-training • Attitude toward company (those committed to its success will be more interested in program)
Letter offering special financing on a new or used car	College students	• Income • Expectations of future income (and ability to repay loan) • Interest in having a new car • Attitude toward cars offered by that dealership • Knowledge of interest rates • Access to other kinds of financing
Letter giving a meeting agenda and saying that you will bring your child along	Client	• How well the client knows you • How much the client likes you • How important agenda items are to the client • How the client feels about children • Physical space for meeting (room for child to play)



When Louisiana Representative John Fleming downplayed his annual income of $6 million on MSNBC while discussing his opposition to taxes on the rich, he raised the eyebrows of interviewer Chris Jansing. Fleming pointed out he actually takes home only about $600,000, with $200,000 less after meeting living expenses, to which Lansing stated, "You do understand, congressman, that the average person out there who's making maybe 40, 50, $60,000 out there, when they hear you only have $400,000 left over, it's not exactly a sympathetic position." How audiences interpret messages depends on both the facts being presented and their emotional reactions to them.

Source: Chris Moody, "Rep. John Fleming Fields Criticism Over 600K Income," September 20, 2011, http://news.yahoo.com/blogs/ticket/rep-john-fleming-field-criticism-over-600k-income-153305241.html.

Knowledge

Even people in your own organization won't share all your knowledge. USAA provides insurance to military personnel and their families, but not all the 22,000 people who work there know insurance jargon.[2]

Most of the time, you won't know exactly what your audience knows. Moreover, even if you've told readers before, they may not remember the old information when they read the new message. To remind readers of information in a tactful way,

- Preface statements with "As you know," "As you may know," or a similar phrase.
- Spell out acronyms the first time you use them: "Employee Stock Ownership Plan (ESOP)."
- Give brief definitions in the text: "the principal—the money you have invested—."
- Put information readers should know in a subordinate clause: "Because the renovation is behind schedule, . . ."

Demographic Factors

Demographic characteristics are measurable features that can be counted objectively: age, sex, race, religion, education level, income, and so on.

Sometimes demographic information is irrelevant; sometimes it's important. Does age matter? Most of the time, probably not. (Mick Jagger is more than 60 years old, but he probably doesn't subscribe to *Modern Maturity.*) On the other hand, if you were explaining a change in your company's pension plan, you'd expect older workers to be more concerned than younger workers.

Business and nonprofit organizations get demographic data by surveying their customers, clients, and donors; by using U.S. census data; or by purchasing demographic



Site to See

Go to

http://www.census.gov/

for demographic information about the U.S. population and more. To get information on your community, click on "American Factfinder."



Keep audiences in mind when using social networking sites. Lee Landor, deputy press secretary to Scott M. Stringer, Manhattan borough president, resigned after her reference to President Barack Obama as "O-dumb-a" and racially tinged comments during a heated exchange about the arrest of Harvard scholar Henry Louis Gates, Jr., on Facebook became public. Her situation rivals that of a woman in the United Kingdom who posted "OMG I HATE MY JOB!" after insulting her boss . . . and then found out he was a Facebook friend. She not only lost the job with two weeks left on her probationary period, but the exchange went viral on the web.

Source: Sewell Chan, "Facebook Postings Prompt Quick Exit of a City Politician's Aide," *The New York Times,* July 28, 2009, http://www.nytimes.com/2009/07/29/nyregion/29fired.html?_r=2; and Marisa Taylor, "The Perils of Oversharing on Facebook," *The Wall Street Journal,* August 21, 2009, http://blogs.wsj.com/digits/2009/08/21/the-perils-of-oversharing-on-facebook/.

data from marketing companies. For many messages, simply identifying subsets of your audience is enough. For example, a school board trying to win support for a tax increase knows that not everyone living in the district will have children in school. It isn't necessary to know the exact percentages to realize that successful messages will need to appeal not only to parents but also to voters who won't directly benefit from the improvements that the tax increase will fund.

Personality

When your primary audience is just one person, his or her personality is relevant. There are many ways to analyze personality. For business, one of the most useful is the **Myers-Briggs Type Indicator®** instrument, which uses four pairs of dichotomies to identify ways that people differ.[3]

- **Extraversion–Introversion:** where someone gets energy. Introverted types get their energy from within; extraverted types are energized by interacting with other people.
- **Sensing–Intuition:** how someone gets information. Sensing types gather information through their senses, preferring what is real and tangible. Intuitive types prefer to look at the big picture, focusing on the relationships and connections between facts.
- **Thinking–Feeling:** how someone makes decisions. Thinking types consider logical consequences of an action to reach decisions. Feeling types make decisions based on the impact to people.
- **Judging–Perceiving:** how someone orients himself or herself to the external world. Judging types like to live in a planned, orderly way, seeking closure. Perceiving types prefer a flexible environment, enjoying possibilities.

Some businesses administer the Myers-Briggs Type Indicator® instrument to all employees. They find that results can be used to assist with team building and/or personal growth and development.

Knowing your audience's personality type can help you select the appropriate channel and craft your message. For instance, an introvert might want a written message because it favors contemplation, while an extravert might instead prefer the dynamics of a phone call or face-to-face meeting. Sensitive types look for detailed facts, arranged sequentially so they can judge each accordingly, while intuitive types want to know the overall situation first to then apply creative solutions.

You'll be most persuasive if you play to your audience's strengths. Indeed, many of the general principles of business communication reflect the types most common among managers. Putting the main point up front satisfies the needs of judging types, and some 75% of U.S. managers are judging. Giving logical reasons satisfies the needs of the nearly 80% of U.S. managers who are thinking types.[4]

Know that human beings are also adaptable. For instance, some research suggests that while only 50% of Americans are estimated to be extraverts, the vast majority of managers and executives demonstrate extraverted personality traits.[5] Introverts can learn many of the associated behaviors, even if they're not their inclination.



Site to See

Go to

www.claritas.com/MyBestSegments/Default.jsp?ID=20

Key in your Zip code to learn which psychographic groups are most common in your neighborhood.

Values and Beliefs

Psychographic characteristics are qualitative rather than quantitative: values, beliefs, goals, and lifestyles. For example, two families living next door to each other might make about the same amount of money and each have two children. But one family might save every possible penny for college and retirement, taking inexpensive vacations and cooking meals at home rather than eating out. The other family might spend almost everything they make on clothes, cars, vacations, entertainment, and dinners out. One family might do most things together as a family, while in the other members might spend most of their time on individual activities. The families might have different religious and political beliefs.

If you wanted to persuade each family to do the same thing, you might need to use different reasons and reader benefits; you would have different objections to overcome.

Knowing what your audience finds important allows you to organize information in a way that seems natural to your audience and to choose appeals that audience members will find persuasive.

Many marketers use the **Values and Lifestyles (VALS)** profiles developed by the SRI research firm in California. VALS profiles divide U.S. buyers into eight categories according to their primary motivation, the amount of resources they have, and the extent to which they innovate. For instance, Strivers are motivated by achievement and are relatively low in resources and innovation. These conspicuous consumers try to be in style, even without a lot of money.

Innovators, on the other hand, may have more disposable income and enjoy cooking and fine food. As Patricia Breman, a senior consultant for SRI Consulting Business Intelligence, points out, Innovators may be an excellent target market for upscale grocery stores.[6]

The other VALS categories are Thinkers, Believers, Achievers, Experiencers, Makers, and Survivors.[7]

Researcher Mary Modahl's survey of 250,000 households found that online buying depends not on demographics such as age and Zip code but on psychographics: the consumer's attitude toward technology along a continuum from "profoundly suspicious" to "eagerly accepting."[8]

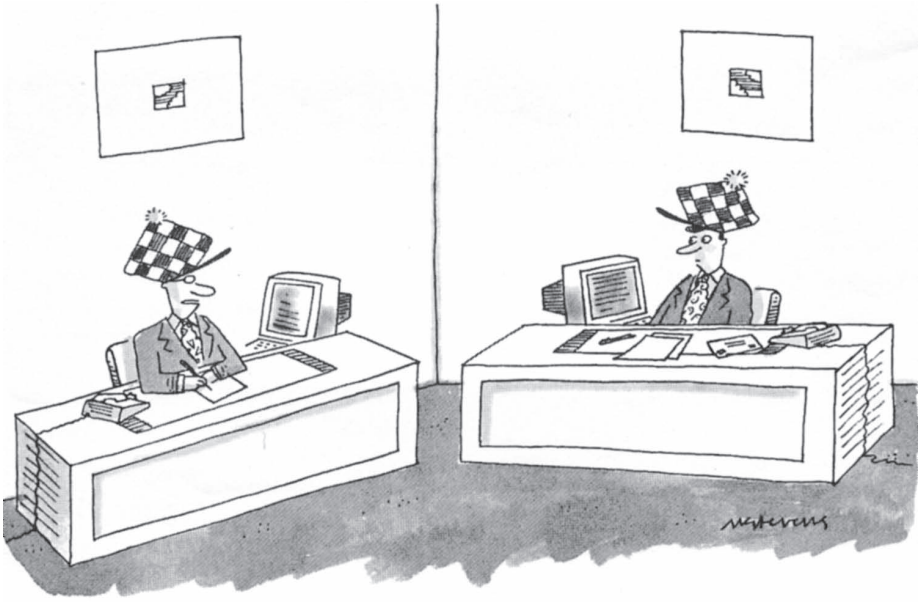
Past Behavior

How people have behaved in the past often predicts how they'll behave in the future. For example, examining records of customer purchases showed Fingerhut that customers who moved made large purchases of furniture and decorations. Fingerhut developed a "mover's catalog" filled with products likely to appeal to this group—and saved money by not mailing other catalogs to this group right after they moved.[9]

Analyzing People in Organizations

Your reader's reaction is affected not only by his or her personal preferences and feelings but also by the discourse communities to which the reader belongs and by the organizational culture.

Some aspects of corporate culture may no longer serve an obvious purpose.



"I don't know how it started, either. All I know is that it's part of our corporate culture."

Copyright © 1994 Mick Stevens/The New Yorker Collection, www.cartoonbank.com.



Ken Blanchard is now a successful business writer with a track record of bestsellers, including *The One Minute Manager,* but people used to tell him he wrote poorly. Blanchard has said that when he was a student in graduate school, professors told him he could not write well enough to succeed as a college professor. But he adds, "Later I learned that the problem with my writing from their point of view was that you could understand it, which meant it wasn't academic enough." At the time, however, he accepted the advice and pursued a career in administration. To date, Blanchard's books have sold more than 20 million copies. His latest is *Great Leaders Grow: Becoming a Leader in Life.*

Source: Based on Kevin Ryan, *Write Up the Corporate Ladder* (New York: Amacom, 2003), 126–27; and Dan Schawbel, "Ken Blanchard on How Great Leaders Grow," *Forbes,* March 1, 2012, http://www.forbes.com/sites/danschawbel/2012/03/01/ken-blanchard-on-howgreat-leaders-grow/.



When State Department spokesman P.J. Crowley called the U.S. Army's treatment of a soldier suspected of collaborating with Wikileaks "stupid" and "ridiculous," he may have been speaking off the cuff. But the remarks generated enough criticism that Crowley later resigned, illustrating among other things the need to carefully weigh audience when communicating. In particular, consider organizational culture and discourse community—a comment that might be acceptable to one group may be unacceptable to another, even if that group includes peers.

Source: Matthew Lee, "Clinton Spokesman Resigns After Wikileaks Flap," *MSNBC,* March 13, 2011, http://www.msnbc.msn.com/id/42060000/ns/politics-more_politics/t/clinton-spokesman-resigns-after-wikileaks-flap/#.UAsP47Se6tw.



Instant Replay

Discourse Community

A **discourse community** is a group of people who share assumptions about what channels, formats, and styles to use, what topics to discuss and how to discuss them, and what constitutes evidence.

A **discourse community** is a group of people who share assumptions about what channels, formats, and styles to use, what topics to discuss and how to discuss them, and what constitutes evidence. Each person is part of several discourse communities, which may or may not overlap.

To analyze an organization's discourse community, ask the following questions:

- What channels, formats, and styles are preferred for communication? Do you write a paper memo, send e-mail, or walk down the hall to talk to someone? How formal or informal are you supposed to be?
- What do people talk about? What is not discussed?
- What kind of and how much evidence is needed to be convincing? Is personal experience convincing? Do you need numbers and formal research?

Procter & Gamble's discourse community requires that recommendations be just one page. So writers create one-page memos—and then add as many pages of "attachments" as they need. In contrast, a Silicon Valley company expects recommendations to be presented as a PowerPoint slide with a triangle with three words around it.

An **organization's culture** is its values, attitudes, and philosophies. Organizational culture (or **corporate culture,** as it is often called; ▶▶ Module 3) is revealed verbally in the organization's myths, stories, and heroes and nonverbally in the allocation of space, money, and power.

The following questions will help you analyze an organization's culture:

- What are the organization's goals? Making money? Serving customers and clients? Advancing knowledge? Contributing to the community?
- What does the organization value? Diversity or homogeneity? Independence or being a team player? Creativity or following orders?
- How do people get ahead? Are rewards based on seniority, education, being well-liked, making technical discoveries, or serving customers? Are rewards available to only a few top people, or is everyone expected to succeed?
- How formal are behavior, language, and dress?

Two companies in the same field may have very different cultures. To compare corporate cultures, Cecilia Rothenberger reviewed how two executives described their own organizations.[10] According to her, Andersen Consulting, which employs 65,000 people in 48 countries, values compensation, bonuses, prestige, resources, and rewards; the 35-person Creative Good firm values communication, relationships, creativity, and growth. Researcher Jennifer Chatman found that new hires who "fit" a company's culture were more likely to stay with the job, be more productive, and be more satisfied than those who did not fit the culture.[11]

Organizations can have subcultures. For example, manufacturing and marketing may represent different subcultures in the same organization: workers may dress differently and have different values.

You can learn about organizational culture by observing people and by listening to the stories they tell. Here are two of the stories Nike's leaders tell.

Story	Lesson
Coach Bowerman (a company co-founder) decided his team needed better running shoes. So he went into his workshop and poured rubber into the family waffle iron to create a waffle sole.	Nike is committed to innovation.
Steve Prefontaine (a runner and another co-founder) worked to make running a professional sport and to get better-performing equipment.	Nike is committed to helping athletes.

You can also learn about a company's culture by looking at its website. Many companies try to describe their cultures, usually as part of the section on employment.

Now that I have my analysis, what do I do with it? LO 2-5

▶ *Use it to plan strategy, organization, style, document design, and visuals.*

If you know your audience well and if you use words well, much of your audience analysis and adaptation will be unconscious. If you don't know your audience or if the message is very important, take the time to analyze your audience formally and to revise your draft with your analysis in mind.

You can adapt your message's strategy, organization, and style to meet the audience's needs. For paper or electronic documents, you can also adapt the document's design and the photos or illustrations you choose.

Strategy

- Make the action as easy as possible.
- Protect the reader's ego.
- Decide how to balance logic and emotion, what details to use, and whether to use a hard-sell or soft-sell approach based on the specific audience, the organizational culture, and the discourse community.
- Choose appeals and reader benefits that work for the specific audience (▶▶ Module 8).
- Modules 7, 11, and 13 will show you how to emphasize positive aspects, decide how much information to include, and overcome obstacles.

Organization

- Because most managers are intuitive types, it's usually better to get to the point right away. The major exceptions are
  - When we must persuade a reluctant reader.
  - When we have bad news and want to let the reader down gradually.
- Make the organizational pattern clear to the audience. Modules 9, 23, and 24 show you how to use headings and overviews. Module 20 shows how to use overviews and signposts in oral presentations.

Style

- For most audiences, use easy-to-understand words, a mixture of sentence lengths, and paragraphs with topic sentences (▶▶ Modules 15 and 16).
- Avoid words that sound defensive or arrogant.
- Avoid hot buttons or "red-flag" words to which some readers will have an immediate negative reaction: *criminal, un-American, crazy, fundamentalist, liberal.*
- Use the language(s) that your audience knows best. In Quebec, messages are normally presented both in English and in French. In the Southwest United States, messages may be most effective printed in both English and Spanish.
- Use conversational, not "academic," language.



"Terrifying," "psychedelic," and "awesomely bad" were among terms critics used to describe an advertisement by California Senate candidate Carly Fiorina's campaign that attacked her opponent, Tom Campbell. The video combined live action with animation to show a flock of sheep infiltrated by a red-eyed, costumed human. While Michael Scherer in *Time* notes the spot is "so weird that you will click on it online," the question remains whether getting attention is the same as swaying the audience.

Source: Brett Michael Dykes, "Bizarre Attack Ad Heats Up California Senate Race," February 4, 2010, http://news.yahoo.com/s/ynews/ynews_pl1112.



To tap into youth markets, companies are seeking advice from people in the target market. Natalie Rodriguez, Heide Panglemaier, and Rosaura Lezama offer their opinions of marketers' efforts through 3iying.com.



Instant Replay

Organizational Culture

An **organization's culture** is its values, attitudes, and philosophies. Organizational culture (or **corporate culture** as it is also called) is revealed verbally in the organization's myths, stories, and heroes and nonverbally in the allocation of space, money, and power.

Document Design

- Use lists, headings, and a mix of paragraph lengths to create white space.
- Choices about format, footnotes, and visuals may be determined by the organizational culture or the discourse community.
- ▶▶ Module 5 for advice about effective document design.

Photographs and Visuals

- Use bias-free photographs and clip art (▶▶ Module 25).
- Photos and visuals can make a document look more informal or more formal. Think of the difference between cartoons and photos of "high art."
- Some cultures (e.g., French, Japanese) use evocative photographs that bear little direct relationship to the text. Most U.S. audiences expect photos that clearly relate to the text, often with a caption that further reinforces the connection.
- For electronic and web documents, consider content and such issues as music or time to download, especially with video or animation.

What if my audiences have different needs? LO 2-6

▶ *Focus on gatekeepers and decision makers.*

When the members of your audience share the same interests and the same level of knowledge, you can use the principles outlined earlier for individual readers or for members of homogenous groups. But often different members of the audience have different needs.

When it is not possible to meet everyone's needs, meet the needs of gatekeepers and primary audiences first.

Content and Choice of Details

- Provide an overview or executive summary for readers who just want the main points.
- In the body of the document, provide enough detail for primary audiences and for anyone else who could veto your proposal.
- If the primary audiences don't need details that other audiences will want, provide those details in appendices—statistical tabulations, earlier reports, and so forth.

Organization

- Use headings and a table of contents so readers can turn to the portions that interest them.
- Organize your message based on the primary audiences' attitudes toward it.

Level of Formality

- Avoid personal pronouns. *You* ceases to have a specific meaning when several different audiences use a document.
- If both internal and external audiences will use a document, use a slightly more formal style than you would in an internal document.
- Use a more formal style when you write to international audiences.

Use of Technical Terms and Theory

- In the body of the document, assume the degree of knowledge that primary audiences will have.
- Put background information and theory under separate headings. Then readers can use the headings and the table of contents to read or skip these sections, as their knowledge dictates.
- If primary audiences will have more knowledge than other audiences, provide a glossary of terms. Early in the document, let readers know that the glossary exists.



Achieving buy-in from audiences can be easier by role-playing first with a friend or colleague to test ideas and prepare for possible objections. That gives you the opportunity to hone the approach.

Source: John Kotter, "If You Think You're Prepared, Think Again," *The Harvard Business Review,* April 19, 2011, http://blogs.hbr.org/kotter/2011/04/if-you-think-youre-prepared-th.html.





The culture at software company Siebel Systems is professional and competitive. Employees can't eat at their desks. Men wear suits; women wear pantsuits or skirted suits with panty hose. Employees are rated, and every year the lowest 5% are fired.

Sun Microsystems' corporate culture fosters informality and flexibility. Employees can use the iWork computer facilities at various Sun drop-in centers, or enroll in the work-from-home program. This provides employees with flexible workplaces and saves valuable driving time, enabling Sun Microsystems to retain the best talent available.

Both companies are now owned by software giant Oracle Corporation.

How do I reach my audience(s)? LO 2-7

▶ *Important messages may require multiple channels.*

Communication channels vary in

- Speed
- Accuracy of transmission
- Cost
- Number of messages carried
- Number of people reached
- Efficiency
- Ability to promote goodwill



The family of Sergeant Jesse Jasper received a "red line" phone call that he, along with Sergeant Tyler Judin, had been killed in action. What they didn't learn until hours later was that Jasper was alive and well. As a result, the U.S. Army's 82nd Airborne Division is reconsidering how its family readiness group notifies all families of individual deaths within the unit. While Jasper's father said, "I don't know why they would tell us about someone else's tragedy," the unit is considering revising messages to start with "Your son or daughter is fine" when that is the case.

Source: Carolyn Thompson, "NY Dad Told Soldier-Son Killed in War—He Wasn't," September 16, 2009, http://news.yahoo.com/s/ap/20090916/ap_on_re_us/us_afghanistan_not_dead.

Depending on your purposes, the audience, and the situation, one channel may be better than another.

A written message makes it easier to

- Present many specific details of a law, policy, or procedure.
- Present extensive or complex financial data.
- Minimize undesirable emotions.

Messages on paper are more formal than e-mail messages. E-mail messages are appropriate for routine messages to people you already know. Paper is usually better for someone to whom you're writing for the first time.

Oral messages make it easier to

- Answer questions, resolve conflicts, and build consensus.
- Use emotion to help persuade the audience.
- Get immediate action or response.
- Focus the audience's attention on specific points.
- Modify a proposal that may not be acceptable in its original form.

Scheduled meetings and oral presentations are more formal than phone calls or stopping someone in the hall.

Important messages should use more formal channels, whether they're oral or written. Oral and written messages have many similarities. In both, you should

- Adapt the message to the specific audience.
- Show the audience members how they benefit from the idea, policy, service, or product (▶▶ Module 8).
- Overcome any objections the audience may have.
- Use you-attitude and positive emphasis (▶▶ Modules 6 and 7).
- Use visuals to clarify or emphasize material (▶▶ Module 25).
- Specify exactly what the audience should do.

Even when everyone in an organization has access to the same channels, different discourse communities may prefer different ones. When a university updated its employee benefits manual, the computer scientists and librarians wanted the information online. Faculty wanted to be able to read the information on paper. Maintenance workers and carpenters wanted to get answers on voice mail.[12]

The bigger your audience, the more complicated channel choice becomes because few channels reach everyone in your target audience. When possible, use multiple channels. Also use multiple channels for very important messages. For example, talk to key players about a written document before the meeting where the document will be discussed.

Summary of Learning Objectives

- Succeeding in an organization depends first on understanding what "counts" at your organization. To find out what counts in your organization, ask your boss thoughtful questions, listen to the stories colleagues tell about people who have succeeded and those who have failed, and observe who is praised and promoted. **(LO 2-1)**
- The **primary audience** will make a decision or act on the basis of your message. The **secondary audience** may be asked by the primary audience to comment on your message or to implement your ideas after they've been approved. The **initial audience** routes the message to other audiences and may assign the message. A **gatekeeper** controls whether the message gets to the primary audience. A **watchdog audience** has political, social, or economic power and may base future actions on its evaluation of your message. **(LO 2-2)**
- A sender goes through the following steps: **perception, interpretation, choice** or **selection, encoding, transmitting** the message through a **channel.** The receiver perceives the message, **decodes** it, interprets it, chooses a response, encodes the response, and transmits it. The message transmitted to the original sender is called **feedback. Noise** is anything that interferes with communication; it can be both physical and psychological. Miscommunication can occur at every point in the communication process. **(LO 2-3)**
- **Channel overload** occurs when a channel cannot handle all the messages being sent. **Information overload** occurs when

the receiver cannot process all the messages that arrive. Both kinds of overload require some sort of selection to determine which messages will be sent and which ones will be attended to. **(LO 2-3)**

- Common sense and empathy are crucial to good audience analysis. **(LO 2-3)**
- A **discourse community** is a group of people who share assumptions about what channels, formats, and styles to use, what topics to discuss and how to discuss them, and what constitutes evidence. **(LO 2-4)**
- An **organization's culture** is its values, attitudes, and philosophies. Organizational culture is revealed verbally in the organization's myths, stories, and heroes and nonverbally in the allocation of space, money, and power. **(LO 2-4)**
- Almost everything about your audience is relevant to some message. But for any particular message, only a few facts about your audience will be relevant. Use **empathy** to put yourself in "someone else's shoes," and look at such factors as knowledge, demographics, personality, psychographics, past behavior, discourse community, and organizational culture. **(LO 2-4)**
- If you don't know your audience or if the message is very important, take the time to analyze your audience formally and to revise your draft with your analysis in mind. You can adapt your message's strategy, organization, and style to meet the audience's needs. For paper or electronic documents, you can also adapt the document's design and the photos or illustrations you choose. **(LO 2-5)**
- When you write to multiple audiences, use the primary audience and the gatekeeper to determine level of detail, organization, level of formality, and use of technical terms and theory. **(LO 2-6)**
- You can adapt your message's strategy, organization, and style to meet the audience's needs. For paper or electronic documents, you can also adapt the document's design and the photos or illustrations you choose. **(LO 2-6)**
- The best channel for a message will depend on the audience, the sender's purposes, and the situation. Channel choice may be shaped by the organizational culture. **(LO 2-7)**
- When you communicate to a big audience or talk about an important topic, use multiple channels. **(LO 2-7)**

Assignments for Module 2

Questions for Comprehension

2.1 What are the five kinds of audiences? **(LO 2-2)**

2.2 What are ways to analyze your audience? **(LO 2-3, LO 2-4)**

2.3 What are three ways to adapt your message to your audience? **(LO 2-5, LO 2-6)**

Questions for Critical Thinking

2.4 Emphasizing the importance of audience, marketers frequently say, "The customer is in control." To what extent do you feel in control as a customer, a student, a citizen? What actions could you take to increase your control? **(LO 2-1 to LO 2-3)**

2.5 If you are employed, which aspects of your organization's culture match your own values? What kind of culture would you like to join when you are next on the job market? **(LO 2-1 to LO 2-3)**

2.6 Why do internal audiences, especially your boss, sometimes feel more important than primary audiences outside your organization? **(LO 2-1 to LO 2-3)**

2.7 What are your options if your boss's criteria for a document are different than those of the primary audience? **(LO 2-1 to LO 2-3)**

Exercises and Problems

2.8 Identifying Audiences (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

In each of the following situations, label the audiences as initial, gatekeeper, primary, secondary, or watchdog:

1. Andrea, a financial planner, wants to hold a dinner seminar for married couples to help them with their financial planning. Her specialty is setting up retirement accounts, but she also wants to help parents save money for their child's college expenses. Before she can hold her seminar, she has to make sure she has the proper licensing and permits in her community as well as schedule catering and meeting space at a local hotel or business center. She has paid for a mailing list of 200 people and their spouses, with hopes that at least 30 couples will attend. As an enticement, she will award several prizes, including theater tickets, a bicycle, and a weekend vacation at a bed and breakfast, all donated from local vendors who would like their businesses recognized at the seminar.
2. Carmale hopes to get a franchise for a casual dining restaurant. She will need to fill out an application with the corporation and also show that she has secured a loan for the balance of costs to build the restaurant.
3. Paul works for the mayor's office in a big city. As part of a citywide cost-cutting measure, a blue-ribbon panel has recommended requiring employees who work more than 40 hours in a week to take compensatory time off rather than being paid overtime. The only exceptions will be the police and fire departments. The mayor asks

Paul to prepare a proposal for the city council, which will vote on whether to implement the change. Before they vote, council members will hear from (1) citizens, who will have an opportunity to read the proposal and communicate their opinions to the city council; (2) mayors' offices in other cities that may be asked about their experiences; (3) union representatives, who may be concerned about the reduction in income that will occur if the proposal is implemented; (4) department heads, whose ability to schedule work might be limited if the proposal passes; and (5) the blue-ribbon panel and good-government lobbying groups. Council members come up for reelection in six months.

2.9 Choosing a Channel to Reach a Specific Audience (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

Suppose that your business, government agency, or nonprofit group has a product, service, or program targeted for each of the following audiences. What would be the best channel(s) to reach people in that group in your city? Would that channel reach all group members?

1. Commuters
2. Internet bulletin board users
3. Retired pilots
4. African Americans
5. Police officers
6. Asian-American voters
7. Outdoor enthusiasts
8. Financial planners
9. College freshmen
10. People thinking about a second career

2.10 Analyzing a Discourse Community (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

Analyze the way a group you are part of uses language. Possible groups include

- Work teams
- Sports teams
- Honor organizations and other service or social groups
- Churches, synagogues, temples, and mosques
- Geographic or ethnic groups
- Groups of friends

Questions to ask include the following:

- What specialized terms might not be known to outsiders?
- What topics do members talk or write about? What topics are considered unimportant or improper?
- What channels do members use to convey messages?
- What forms of language do members use to build goodwill? To demonstrate competence or superiority?
- What strategies or kinds of proof are convincing to members?
- What formats, conventions, or rules do members expect messages to follow?

As Your Instructor Directs,

a. Share your results orally with a small group of students.
b. Present your results in an oral presentation to the class.
c. Present your results in a memo to your instructor.
d. Share your results in an e-mail message to the class.
e. Share your results with a small group of students and write a joint memo reporting the similarities and differences you found.

2.11 Analyzing an Organization's Culture (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

Interview several people about the culture of their organization. Possible organizations include

- Work teams
- Sports teams
- Honor organizations and other service or social groups
- Churches, synagogues, temples, and mosques
- Geographic or ethnic groups
- Groups of friends

Questions to ask include those in this module and the following:

1. Tell me about someone in this organization you admire. Why is he or she successful?
2. Tell me about someone who failed in this organization. What did he or she do wrong?
3. What ceremonies and rituals does this organization have? Why are they important?
4. Why would someone join this group rather than a competitor?

As Your Instructor Directs,

a. Share your results orally with a small group of students.
b. Present your results in an oral presentation to the class.
c. Present your results in a memo to your instructor.
d. Share your results in an e-mail message to the class.
e. Share your results with a small group of students and write a joint memo reporting the similarities and differences you found.

2.12 Analyzing the Audiences of Noncommercial Web Pages (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

Analyze the implied audiences of two web pages of two noncommercial organizations with the same purpose (combating hunger, improving health, influencing the political process, etc.). You could pick pages of the national organization and a local affiliate, or pages of two separate organizations working toward the same general goal.

Answer the following questions:

- Do the pages work equally well for surfers and for people who have reached the page deliberately?
- Possible audiences include current and potential volunteers, donors, clients, and employees. Do the pages provide material for each audience? Is the

material useful? Complete? Up-to-date? Does new material encourage people to return?
- What assumptions about audience do content and visuals suggest?
- Can you think of ways that the pages could better serve their audiences?

As Your Instructor Directs,

a. Share your results orally with a small group of students.
b. Present your results in an oral presentation to the class.
c. Present your results in a memo to your instructor. Attach copies of the web pages.
d. Share your results with a small group of students and write a joint memo reporting the similarities and differences you found.
e. Post your results in an e-mail message to the class. Provide links to the two web pages.

2.13 Analyzing People in Your Organization (LO 2-1 to LO 2-4)

1. Analyze your supervisor.
   - Does he or she like short or long explanations?
   - Does he or she want to hear about all the problems in a unit or only the major ones?
   - How important are punctuality and deadlines?
   - How well informed about a project does he or she wish to be?
   - Is he or she more approachable in the morning or the afternoon?
   - What are your supervisor's major hassles?
2. Analyze other workers in your organization.
   - Is work "just a job" or do most people really care about the organization's goals?
   - How do workers feel about clients or customers?
   - What are your co-workers' major hassles?
3. Analyze your customers or clients.
   - What attitudes do they have toward the organization and its products or services?
   - What are their major hassles?
   - Do education, age, or other factors affect the way they read?

As Your Instructor Directs,

a. Write a memo to your instructor summarizing your analysis.
b. Discuss your analysis with a small group of students.
c. Present your analysis orally to the class.
d. Combine your information with classmates' information to present a collaborative report comparing and contrasting your audiences at work.

2.14 Persuading a Lender to Defer Paying a Student Loan (LO 2-2)

Many college graduates today leave school with large debts from student loans. Though the loans must be repaid, the time to do so and the monthly payment are determined by the lender. With a tough economy making it harder to find a job, students may also find it harder to repay loans. Many lenders, however, expect them to start doing so upon graduation. You plan to request a deferral to start paying back your loan.

To do so, answer the following questions about your audience.

- What is at stake for the lender if it defers the loan?
- What regulating bodies (e.g., state and federal government) govern how a lender may alter the terms of a loan agreement?
- What objections might a lender raise to deferring the loan?
- What other resources might the lender suggest tapping in order to repay the loan?
- What might the lender expect from you as a guarantee that you will repay the loan after the deferral?
- What channel is the best way to reach the lender?
- What tone will work best in the message to the lender?

2.15 Sending a Question to a Website (LO 2-2, LO 2-3)

Send a question or other message that calls for a response to a website. (►► Problem 13.12.) You could

- Ask a question about a product.
- Apply for an internship or a job (assuming you'd really like to work there).
- Ask for information about an internship or a job.
- Ask a question about an organization or a candidate before you donate money or volunteer.
- Offer to volunteer for an organization or a candidate. You can offer to do something small and one-time (e.g., spend an afternoon stuffing envelopes, put up a yard sign), or you can, if you want to, offer to do something more time-consuming or even ongoing.

Pick a specific organization you might use and answer these questions about it.

- Does the organization ask for questions or offers? Or will yours "come out of the blue"?
- How difficult will it be for the organization to supply the information you're asking for or to do what you're asking it to do? If you're applying for an internship or offering to volunteer, what skills can you offer? How much competition do you have?
- What can you do to build your own credibility so the organization takes your question or request seriously?

2.16 Convincing Your Organization to Allow Flex-Time for Students (LO 2-2, LO 2-3)

Your organization has a generous tuition reimbursement program, but currently employees must take classes outside of regular business hours. You've noticed that many classes you want or need at the local university are offered infrequently during evenings and weekends. If a class is already full or you have another commitment, you often have to wait months before a seat is available. Your co-workers are similarly affected.

You plan to write a memo to upper management describing your solution: flex-time for full-time employees going to school. Your solution would allow employees to reschedule up to five hours each week to take classes during work hours. Employees could make up hours in the mornings, evenings, or weekends and could only reschedule hours if meetings and other work-related duties don't conflict.

Pick an organization you know something about and answer the following questions:

- What is the purpose of the tuition reimbursement program?
- How do employees benefit? How does the organization benefit?
- Will it cost the company money or lost efficiency to offer flex-time?
- What obstacles must be overcome regarding organizational culture?
- How will employee schedules be tracked? Who will be responsible?
- How would you deal with the objection that employees could take distance-learning courses, such as those offered on the web?
- What is the company's competitive position? Is it growing? Shrinking?

2.17 Announcing Holiday Diversity (LO 2-2, LO 2-3)

To better respect the religious and ethnic diversity of your employees, your organization will now allow employees to take any 10 days off. (▶▶ Problem 13.9.) Any religious, ethnic, or cultural holiday is acceptable. (Someone who wants to take off Cinco de Mayo or Bastille Day can do so.) As Vice President for Human Resources, you need to announce the policy.

Pick a specific organization you know something about and answer these questions about it.

- What religious and ethnic groups do your employees come from?
- How much do various groups know about each others' holidays?
- What is the general climate for religious and ethnic tolerance? Should the message have a secondary purpose of educating people about less-common holidays?
- Is your organization open every day of the year, or will you be closed on some holidays (e.g., Christmas, New Year's Day)? If an employee chooses to work on a day when offices or factories are closed, what should he or she do? Work at home? Get a key? (How? From whom?) What kinds of work could a person working alone most profitably do?



Polishing Your Prose

Comma Splices

In filmmaking, editors might *splice,* or connect, two segments of film with tape to create one segment. A *comma splice* occurs when writers try to create one sentence by connecting two sentences with only a comma.

Correct: We shipped the order on Tuesday. It arrived on Wednesday.

Incorrect: We shipped the order on Tuesday, it arrived on Wednesday. (comma splice)

Comma splices are almost always inappropriate in business communication. (Poetry and fiction sometimes use comma splices to speed up action or simulate dialect; some sales letters and advertisements use comma splices for the same effect, though not always successfully.)

Fix a comma splice in one of four ways:

1. If the ideas in the sentences are closely related, use a semicolon:
   We shipped the order on Tuesday; it arrived on Wednesday.
2. Add a coordinating conjunction (such as *and, or,* or *but*):
   We shipped the order on Tuesday, and it arrived on Wednesday.
3. Make the incorrect sentence into two correct ones:
   We shipped the order on Tuesday. It arrived on Wednesday.
4. Subordinate one of the clauses:
   Because we shipped the order on Tuesday, it arrived on Wednesday.

Exercises

Fix the comma splices in the following sentences.

1. Dress appropriately for your job interview, wear your best suit.
2. Wednesday was the last time we did anything on our Facebook page, ask Sandy to post an update on our news feed, please.
3. Because of storms, Ethan's flight was delayed, he arrived in Tulsa 30 minutes after the ceremony started but was able to give his speech.
4. Suri decided to hold the meeting online, that will save a considerable amount of money in our travel budget.
5. We've narrowed down our hiring choices to Michael, Isabella, and Dylan, we should schedule another round of interviews to make our final decision.
6. The Purchasing Department needs copies of your receipts from the Kyoto trip, if you submit them by Friday, you will be reimbursed.
7. Liudmila and Carlos developed the reorganization plan for Gemma Infotech, in a display of interdepartmental cooperation, Linda, Mehran, and Alex helped to revise it.
8. About an hour after the executive council meeting, we got a call that the proposal had been accepted, needless to say, it was great news for the team!
9. Dr. Faulkner, head of the Savannah research project, asked us to send the report directly to the CDC, we should hear confirmation of the findings by April 20.
10. Lani Kapur, who graduated from Oxford University and spent several years in Geneva, is fluent in French and German, she would be an excellent candidate to lead the consulting team in Western Europe.

Check your answers to the odd-numbered exercises at the back of the book.